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Cultivating safe space in hostile places: the case of the Marathon of Afghanistan

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ABSTRACT

"There wasn't participation in running before this event, or any female participation in sport at all for that matter... In just 3 years, the race has really become a symbol of these girls having an opportunity, and some equality in sport." (Respondent 2)

Afghanistan is a country afflicted by protracted conflict, recurrent natural disasters, and social and economic inequality. Until 2001, the Taliban controlled the country, imposing strict religious laws and restrictions on women and girls' participation in public life. Nearly twenty years later, little has improved in the way of access to education for women and girls, let alone sport opportunities, due to lingering cultural restrictions and widespread fear of conflict. Despite these challenges, a group of local and international volunteers in Bamiyan, a province of Central Afghanistan, founded the country's first public, outdoor, co-ed sport event: The Marathon of Afghanistan. Through structured interviews a media analysis, a framework was developed to show the mediating role of relationship building in the creation of safe space for an event in unstable or hostile environments.

Marathon of AFGHANISTAN | اتصالات etisalat

INTRODUCTION

- Sport for development is the 'use of sport to exert a positive influence" (Lyras & Welty Peachey, 2011, p.311). Positive outcomes from sport are not automatically bestowed (Spaaij & Schulenkorf, 2014), they must be planned and managed.
- In the production of effective sport-for-development programs and events, safety must be considered a top priority (Spaaij & Schulenkorf, 2014).
- **Safe space** refers to not only physical safety, but "protection from psychological or emotional harm", or space in which participants "openly express their individuality" (Holley & Steiner, 2005, p. 50).
- Spaaij and Schulenkorf (2014) identified **five dimensions of safe space: physical, psychological, sociocultural, political, and experimental.**
- This study extends Spaaij and Schulenkorf's (2014) conceptualization of safe space by elaborating on *how* safe space is planned.
- The case is the Marathon of Afghanistan, an annual event inaugurated in October 2015. The date is unannounced to ensure the safety of the event. The race is co-ed, despite many cultural barriers for women. The event is widely supported by government officials in the province of Bamiyan, police, Afghani military, and sponsors.









METHODS

1. Semi-structured interviews with organizers, participants, and sponsors (N = 10). Purposeful sampling and snowball sampling were used and data collection stopped once all referred English-speaking respondents had been interviewed and no new data was produced (Cresswell, 2009).
2. The interviews were transcribed and thematically coded by the first author using the dimensions of safe space as themes (Spaaij & Schulenkorf, 2014).
3. A media analysis of newspaper articles was conducted (Bowden, 2009). Articles were collected using keyword search of the event title ('Marathon of Afghanistan') on Google News; 17 were retained (Creswell & Miller, 2000).
4. Articles were manually coded by both authors using the same deductive themes from the interview analysis (Fereday & Muir-Cochrane, 2006).

RESULTS

1. **<u>Interviewees and news articles uniformly stressed the importance of safety in the event.</u>**
All five dimensions of safe space were identified (directly or indirectly) in the interviews and media documents; the most commonly mentioned were sociocultural and physical.

"There was a military convoy that went up and down the course to make sure that the first and last racers were safe." (Respondent 5 commenting on **physical safety**)

"Not every area along the course is secure so there were lots of arrangements and agreements which needed to be made. The local army chief, police chief, and governor, as well as the village leaders, were all on board with it." (Respondent 4 on **physical and political safety**)

*"We work with the local communities, families, teachers, elders, by providing lots of information and education on how the event is managed and the steps we're taking to keep their girls safe." (Respondent 3 on **socio-cultural safety**)*

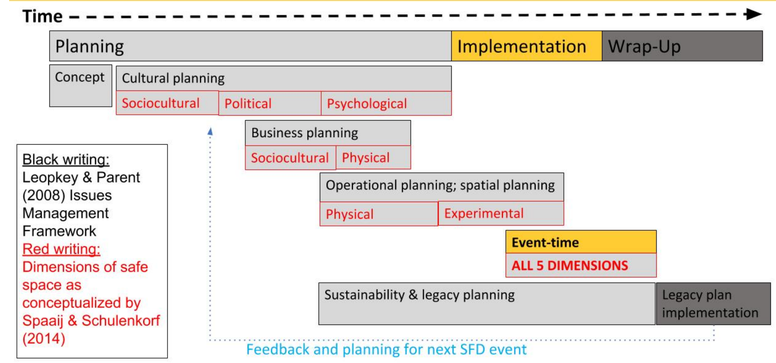
"There's far more acceptance for women running in public since the Marathon started, and far more confidence among runners. We're starting to feel safer in public." (Respondent 6 on **psychological safety**)

"Part of the challenge for us is that we can't market the event in advance, for security reasons, so we have to just turn up and sweep people up and convince them to take part in this race". (Respondent 1 on **experimental safety**)

2. **<u>All dimensions of safe space were created by relationship building.</u>** Securing support from police, military officials, the Governor, and community leaders (which created the socio-cultural and political safe space of the event), was instrumental to the creation of physical, psychological and experimental safe space.

3. The safe space management process was mapped on a timeline that resembles Leopkey & Parent's (2008) Issues Management Framework.

FRAMEWORK



Dimension of safe space	Example of relationship-building for Marathon of Afghanistan
Physical	Partnership with local police and the Afghani military to secure the roads during the race.
Political	Securing and promoting the support of the Governor of Bamiyan.
Psychological	Connecting role models (and mentors) to the female runners to increase confidence in running ability and build a moral support network for participants.
Sociocultural	Distributing pamphlets and information to parents of girls to educate them about running, and normalize the activity.
Experimental	Implementing a closed, word-of-mouth notification system with community members for the announcement of date and location.

DISCUSSION

Merging two frameworks indicates the importance of each, and the added value that each brings to the other. Notably, the safe space framework (Spaaij & Schulenkorf, 2014) is given structure and organizational guidance from the issues framework (Leopkey & Parent, 2008). Additionally, the issues management framework (Leopkey & Parent, 2008) is extended to present a more holistic consideration of safety- in all senses of the word- and translated to a small event context.

This research could be replicated in future using different events with larger sample sizes of respondents. Additionally, future research might use quantitative methods to determine the relative importance of each dimensions of safe space to the success of the event, and weigh the mediating role of relationship building in each dimension of safe space.





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